



Breathe, Screen, Live

Understanding & Managing Hypertension

Your complete guide to controlling high blood pressure and protecting your heart

- What blood pressure numbers mean and why they matter
- Lifestyle changes that can lower your blood pressure
- Medication options and how they work
- Complications to watch for and how to prevent them
- South African context: access to treatment and support

Digital Guide — R50

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What Is Hypertension?

Hypertension, commonly known as high blood pressure, is a condition where the force of blood against your artery walls is consistently too high. Think of it like water pressure in a hose — when the pressure is too high, it puts strain on the entire system.

Blood pressure is measured in millimetres of mercury (mmHg) and recorded as two numbers:

- Systolic (top number): The pressure when your heart beats and pumps blood
- Diastolic (bottom number): The pressure when your heart rests between beats

A normal blood pressure reading is below 120/80 mmHg. Hypertension is diagnosed when readings are consistently 140/90 mmHg or higher. Readings between 120-139/80-89 mmHg are considered "elevated" or "prehypertension" and should be monitored.

Why Is Hypertension Dangerous?

Hypertension is often called the "silent killer" because it typically has no symptoms. Many people walk around with dangerously high blood pressure for years without knowing it. Meanwhile, the constant pressure damages your arteries and organs.

Untreated hypertension can lead to:

- Heart attack and heart failure — the heart has to work harder to pump blood
- Stroke — damaged arteries in the brain can rupture or clog
- Kidney damage — delicate blood vessels in the kidneys are easily damaged
- Vision loss — damage to blood vessels in the eyes
- Aneurysm — weakened artery walls can bulge and rupture

Risk Factors

Some risk factors for hypertension are beyond your control:

- Age — risk increases as you get older
- Family history — hypertension often runs in families
- Ethnicity — people of African descent are at higher risk
- Chronic conditions — diabetes, kidney disease, and sleep apnoea increase risk

But many risk factors are within your control:

- Being overweight or obese
- A diet high in salt and low in potassium
- Lack of physical activity
- Excessive alcohol consumption
- Smoking
- Chronic stress

Lifestyle Changes That Work

Lifestyle modifications are the foundation of hypertension management. In many cases, they can reduce or even eliminate the need for medication.

Reduce Your Salt Intake

South Africans consume an average of 8-10 grams of salt per day — double the recommended maximum of 5 grams (about one teaspoon). Salt causes your body to retain water, which increases blood volume and pressure.

Tips to cut salt:

- Don't add salt at the table — taste your food first
- Use herbs, spices, garlic, and lemon instead of salt for flavouring
- Check food labels — choose products with less than 400mg sodium per 100g
- Limit processed foods, takeaways, and restaurant meals
- Rinse canned vegetables and beans to remove excess salt

Eat a Balanced Diet

The DASH (Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension) diet is specifically designed to lower blood pressure. It emphasises:

- Fruits and vegetables — at least 4-5 servings each per day
- Whole grains — oats, brown rice, wholewheat bread
- Lean proteins — fish, chicken, legumes, nuts
- Low-fat dairy products
- Limited red meat, sweets, and sugary beverages

Get Moving

Regular physical activity strengthens your heart so it can pump blood with less effort. Aim for at least 30 minutes of moderate exercise most days of the week.

Walking is one of the best exercises for blood pressure control. It's free, requires no equipment, and can be done anywhere. Start with 10-minute walks and gradually increase duration and frequency.

Limit Alcohol and Stop Smoking

Alcohol can raise blood pressure, even in moderate amounts. If you drink, limit yourself to one drink per day for women and two for men.

Smoking causes an immediate spike in blood pressure and heart rate. Quitting is one of the most important things you can do for your cardiovascular health.

Medication Options

When lifestyle changes aren't enough, medication can effectively control hypertension. Several types work in different ways:

- Diuretics ("water pills") — help your kidneys remove excess sodium and water
- ACE inhibitors — relax blood vessels by blocking the formation of a hormone that narrows them
- ARBs (Angiotensin II receptor blockers) — protect blood vessels from narrowing
- Calcium channel blockers — relax blood vessel walls
- Beta-blockers — reduce heart rate and the force of heart contractions

Most people need two or more medications to achieve good blood pressure control. It may take time to find the right combination for you. Always take your medication as prescribed — don't stop even if you feel fine.

Monitoring at Home

Home blood pressure monitoring is an essential tool for managing hypertension.

Tips for accurate home monitoring:

- Use a validated automatic upper-arm monitor (not wrist or finger devices)
- Sit quietly for 5 minutes before measuring

- Place the cuff on bare skin at heart level
- Don't smoke, exercise, or drink caffeine within 30 minutes of measuring
- Take readings at the same time each day, morning and evening
- Record your readings and bring them to your appointments

In the South African Context

Hypertension affects approximately 1 in 3 South African adults, making it one of the most common chronic conditions in the country.

- Public healthcare: Blood pressure medication is available at primary healthcare clinics, often free of charge.
- Pharmacies: Many pharmacies offer free blood pressure checks — Clicks, Dis-Chem, and community pharmacies.
- Support: The Heart and Stroke Foundation South Africa (www.heartfoundation.co.za) provides education and resources.

When to See Your Doctor

Seek medical attention if:

- Your blood pressure is consistently above 140/90 mmHg despite treatment
- You experience severe headaches, chest pain, shortness of breath, or vision changes
- Your blood pressure spikes above 180/120 mmHg — a hypertensive crisis requiring immediate attention
- You have side effects from your medication
- You're planning to become pregnant

Disclaimer

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Always consult a qualified healthcare professional for diagnosis, treatment, and management of any health condition. Aliento Health and Dr. Leegale Adonis accept no liability for actions taken based on the information in this guide.

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